

A keepsake for those who come after

A Life in Your Own Words

A Gentle Guide to Telling Your Story



Thank you for sharing your story. This little guide walks you through everything you can do — at your own pace, in your own words. There is no right or wrong way, and nothing you need to finish in one sitting.

Getting Started

1. Open the website

Visit the link you were given on any phone, tablet, or computer. There is nothing to download and no account to create.

2. Tell us who you are

Choose whether you are filling this out **on your own** or **as a couple**, then enter your name and date of birth. That is all that is needed — your name and date of birth are simply how your answers are found again when you come back.

3. Press “Begin or continue”

The same button starts a new story or picks up an existing one. If you have answered before, your previous answers will be waiting for you.

Coming back later? You never lose your place. Just return to the same link and enter your own name and date of birth again. Everything you have written will be exactly where you left it.

Answering the Questions

The questionnaire moves through the chapters of a life — childhood, family, growing up, work, marriage, later years, and more. Each section holds a handful of questions.

Answer as much or as little as you like. Skip any question that does not apply, and spend as long as you wish on the ones that stir a memory. Nothing is required.

Your work saves itself. A moment after you stop typing, your answer is safely stored — there is no save button to remember and nothing to lose if you close the page.

Move around freely. Use the *Back* and *Next* buttons at the top or bottom of each page, or tap any section name in the row of buttons to jump straight there. A progress bar shows how far along you are.

Add your own questions. At the bottom of each section you will find *+ Add your own question*. Use it to ask and answer anything the questionnaire did not — a story, a person, a moment that matters to you. You can add as many as you like, and give each its own photos. These are yours alone and appear only in your story.

Take your time. Many people answer a few questions, step away, and return over days or weeks. That is exactly how it is meant to be used.

Adding Photos

Photographs bring a story to life. Adding them is entirely optional, but they are a lovely touch.

A photo for any memory. Beneath most questions you will find an *+ Add a photo* button. Tap it to choose a picture from your device. You can add several to a single question.

Photos for a whole chapter. At the top of each section there is also a place to add photos that belong to that time of your life as a whole, rather than to one question. In your finished book these open the chapter as a lovely arrangement — one large picture on its own, or a tidy grouping when there are several.

Captions and order. Under each photo you can type a short caption (for example, “*Our wedding day, 1962*”), and use the arrow buttons to arrange photos in the order you prefer.

A cover photo. On the first page you may choose a favorite portrait for the very front of your book. As with all photos, this is optional and can be changed or removed at any time.

To remove a photo, tap the small × in its corner.

Filling It Out as a Couple

If you choose to answer as a couple, you have a few gentle options for how to share your stories together.

Sign in once, together. Enter both names and dates of birth at the start. From then on, **either** of you can come back and sign in with just your own name and date of birth — you will both reach the same shared story.

Answer together or separately. Each question has a small *Together / Separately* choice. Choose *Together* for one shared answer, or *Separately* to give each of you your own space to respond in your own words.

Changing your mind. If you begin together but later decide you would each rather have your own separate story, choose “*fill out separately*”. Your shared answers are kept and copied for each of you, and from then on you each continue independently.

A note for couples returning later: there is no need to re-enter both names. Whichever of you sits down to write, simply enter your own name and date of birth, and your shared story will open right where it was left.

Keeping a Copy & Finishing

Preview your book any time. Tap “*preview my book*” to open a window showing how your life story book is coming along — cover, chapters, photos, and all. It is just for looking; nothing is saved or printed.

Close the window when you are done and carry on where you left off.

Print your own keepsake. At any time you can choose “*print my answers*” (or, when you finish, “*Print or save my book*”). Your answers and photos are laid out as a handsome little book. In the print window you can choose “*Save as PDF*” to keep a copy on your device.

Turn it into a real book. Because your story is laid out as a properly sized book, the saved PDF can be taken or emailed to a local print shop — or an online one such as a photo-book service — to be bound into a physical keepsake you can hold and pass down.

Anything else you wish to say. The final section, *In Your Own Words*, is an open space — a place for any memory, story, or message to your family that the questions did not ask about.

There is no deadline. Even after you reach the end, you are always welcome to return, revisit your answers, and add more whenever a new memory comes to mind.

Your words are a gift — one your family will hold close for generations to come. Thank you for the time and heart you give to telling your story.

